

Campaign Brief: CMP-012 Fall City Breaks 2026

Cymbal Voyages Brand Studio · Agency onboarding packet · Last updated September 2026

Flight dates: July 24, 2026 to October 31, 2026. Brief written July 2026. Retrospective to date added mid-September 2026.

Objective

Launch the fall city-break category with a full-funnel paid-social push, selling three- and four-night city packages for September through November travel to customers who have shown interest in cities. The campaign exists to establish city breaks as a second seasonal pillar alongside warm escapes, so that the business has a fall booking season of its own rather than a quiet stretch before winter sun.

Audience

Segment: `urban_explorers` (customers who viewed or booked city breaks) across all markets, cold-weather, warm and mild alike. Size: about 26,000 contacts, of whom roughly 18,000 are Cymbal Compass members and 8,000 are non-member customers. A lookalike prospecting layer on paid social extends reach beyond the CRM. Propensity summary: the median warm-escape propensity score for this audience is 0.08, with 2 percent at or above 0.30, which is expected; the score models warm-escape intent and is not a guide to city-break intent. The segment is defined by observed behavior, and about 30 percent of it has booked a city break with us before. Exclusions: contacts with an active reservation and unsubscribed contacts.

Insight

City-skyline creative outperformed every other style in the city-break placements of CMP-006 Spring Flash Sale, in every market, even inside a campaign that otherwise underperformed. Urban explorers book differently from warm-escape customers: shorter lead times, shorter stays, more weekend departures, and a stronger response to a named neighborhood or market than to a resort. Fall is the natural season for the category, with cooler weather in the European and northeastern cities and school schedules settled. We have never given this category a launch of its own; it has ridden along in sitewide pushes and never had a chance to show what it can do.

Channels

Paid social is the primary paid channel and carries the full funnel: awareness video for the lookalike prospecting layer, static city-skyline placements for the matched CRM audience, and retargeting for anyone who views a city package. Frequency cap: three impressions per person per seven days for matched and retargeted audiences, two for prospecting. Email carries four sends over the flight to the 26,000-contact audience: a category launch on July 28, a "cities in September" send on August 18, a "cities in October" send on September 15, and a closing send in mid-October. Frequency cap: two marketing sends per week, respected. Direct (site and app) features a city-breaks collection on the home page for the flight. No paid search beyond the always-on brand program, and no organic or affiliate activity is planned.

Offer

No offer for the launch phase, July 24 through September 14. The category is new to most of the audience and we want the packages to sell on curation and price transparency, with "from" pricing per person, taxes and fees included. Bonus points for the fall phase,

September 15 through October 31: Compass members who book a city break receive 3,000 bonus points, worth \$30 toward a future booking, posting within 14 days of completed travel under standard Compass terms. No percent-off, no urgency framing, at any stage.

Budget and modeled reach

Total budget: \$367,800, all of it paid social. Funded by reallocation, not new money: this is the paid-social budget of the always-on Warm Escapes Retargeting program (CMP-002) for July 24 through October 31, rotated to this campaign from July 24, 2026, with CMP-002's paid social paused for the same dates. The figure reflects CMP-002's \$3,000 base daily spend with its warm-escape seasonal multipliers for these months, averaging about \$3,678 per day across 100 flight days. Production, estimated at \$26,000, is carried by the Brand Studio's standing production line and is not charged to the campaign; email media cost sits in the CRM platform budget. Points liability is carried by the Compass reserve and is not campaign cost.

Modeled reach: paid social matched audience of about 15,000 contacts (68 percent match rate), lookalike prospecting reach of about 600,000 people, and roughly 2.4 million impressions over the flight. Email to about 21,000 deliverable addresses at four sends.

KPIs

Booking target: 2,400 confirmed city-break reservations attributed to the campaign by October 31, 2026, with a 30-day post-click window for paid social and a 7-day post-open window for email. ROI target: 1.5 using the standard formula, $(\text{attributed revenue} \times 22 \text{ percent contribution margin} - \text{campaign cost}) \div \text{campaign cost}$. Secondary measures: cost per booking under \$155, prospecting share of bookings above 25 percent, email click rate above 3.5 percent, and 40 percent of Compass-member bookers making their first city-break booking with us.

Creative direction

Imagery: city skyline as the lead style, with an adventure variant (a walking-tour or market scene) as a secondary test on prospecting. Call to action: See deals on prospecting placements, Book now on matched and retargeting placements, and Plan your escape on email. Headline territory: "Three nights in" followed by a city, with one concrete detail per city, such as the Jean-Talon market in Montréal or a Saturday on the Charleston waterfront. Featured cities: New York City, Chicago, Montréal, Charleston, New Orleans, Lisbon, Barcelona, Paris, London, Rome, Amsterdam and Mexico City. Tone note: specific and practical; the copy should help a reader choose a city, not admire one. Test plan: city skyline versus adventure-style imagery on the prospecting layer, and "Three nights in" headlines versus price-led headlines on the matched audience.

Legal review notes

Price disclaimer required on every asset with a "from" price. Loyalty points disclaimer required on all fall-phase assets that mention bonus points. No superlatives about any city; destination copy must clear the banned-phrase list. City imagery must be licensed and must show the city named, not a lookalike. Reviewer and sign-off date: to be completed at legal review.

Retrospective

Results to date, mid-September 2026. Through September 15 the campaign has delivered 640 confirmed bookings on about \$199,000 of the \$367,800 budget, 54 of 100 flight days. Attributed revenue is roughly \$995,000, which at 22 percent contribution margin gives an ROI of 0.1 so far, close to break-even. Cost per booking to date is \$311 against a \$155 target. Average booking value is about \$1,550. The campaign is behind a straight-line pace to 2,400; the plan expected bookings to weight toward September and October because city breaks are booked closer to travel, but reaching the target requires about

1,760 bookings in the remaining 46 days, which would be a sharp change of pace. It is too early to call.

What is working. City-skyline creative is performing well against urban explorers: a 1.9 percent click-through on matched placements against 1.1 percent for the adventure-style variant, and the "Three nights in" headlines are beating price-led headlines by about a third. Montréal and Charleston are the two best-selling cities, followed by Lisbon. Email has carried more than half the bookings to date, with the August 18 send drawing a 4.4 percent click rate. Among Compass-member bookers, 46 percent are booking a city break with us for the first time, ahead of the 40 percent target.

What is not. The lookalike prospecting layer is expensive: prospecting accounts for 18 percent of bookings against a 25 percent target, and most of the cost-per-booking gap sits there. The bonus-points phase began only on September 15, so its effect is not yet measurable. As a matter of record, the Warm Escapes Retargeting program (CMP-002) whose paid-social budget funds this campaign has not been restored, and warm-escape bookings in August came in under plan. Whether those two facts are connected is an open question for the fall planning review.

What we would do differently. Fund a category launch with its own money, or at least decide the trade-off explicitly in the brief rather than by rotation. Shift a larger share of paid social from lookalike prospecting to the matched audience and to retargeting of package viewers, where cost per booking is close to target. Start the points phase at launch for Compass members instead of holding it for the fall phase.